

less money. While money or the opportunity to earn more doesn't need to drive every career and life decision, getting better at what you do, making greater and greater contributions to your employer or community, building a reputation for excellence, setting and meeting aggressive goals are worthy apart from a merit raise or bonus.

## 2. Take excellent care of yourself.

Being frugal should not be hazardous to your well-being, but rather improve your mental outlook and physical health. Cooking at home, a frugality mainstay, is typically less expensive and healthier than the often high-calorie, high-fat, and high-sodium meals from restaurants. But don't stop there. Make sure you get regular health screenings (physicals, blood work, and cancer checks) and push the exercise as much as possible to control weight, and build stamina and strength. You don't have to look frumpy just because you are frugal.

## 3. Go on adventures.

Adventures allow you to 1) have pure fun and 2) give you intriguing stories to tell, further separating you from things-based social status. Whether a backpacking trip on the Appalachian

Trail or a theater- and museum-hopping visit to London, if your experience involves what you love, do it; who doesn't respect someone who dares to live his/her dreams? Frugality just means spending wisely—it doesn't mean never allowing yourself to splurge on trips you can afford.

## 4. Take excellent care of things you own.

Being neither materialistic nor visually attuned to artistic details made it difficult for me to understand the value that society places on appearances. But I finally realized that stewardship should be aligned with ownership, which meant taking care of my possessions: polishing my shoes; getting machines repaired; clearing up water stains; and replacing dented vinyl floors. Making overdue renovations to my home in the past few years made me understand that I can afford nice things though not necessarily super-sized ones of everything. Friends and guests are charmed at fine finishes, not just large structures.

## 5. Stay on top of technology.

You don't have to be an early adopter, but years of eschewing new technology can make you seem like a dinosaur, or worse, just plain slow to grasp